

“THIS IS GOOD NEWS ... IF THE PERSIANS HIDE THE SUN, WE SHALL DO BATTLE IN THE SHADE.”

Herodotus, ancient Greek historian, quoting words attributed to Dieneceas, a Spartan, on being told that the Persian archers shot so many arrows they would conceal the Sun; from *Histories*



Plebeians withdraw from Rome

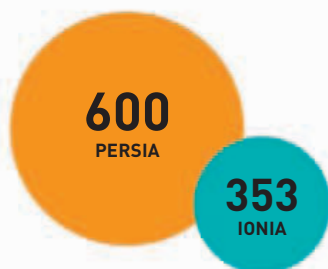
The departure of the plebeians (on the left in this engraving) threatened to split Rome irreparably, so the patricians (right) ceded some political power.

THE GREEK CITY-STATES OF IONIA

in western Anatolia had been subjects of the Persian Empire since Cyrus conquered Lydia, their previous overlord, in 547 BCE (see 550–501 BCE). In 499 BCE, **Aristagoras**, the ruler of Miletus, set out to mainland Greece to recruit allies for a **planned**

uprising against the Persians. Sparta rejected his pleas, but only Athens and Eretria sent forces. A failed attack on Sardis led the Athenian forces to return home. The Ionians gradually lost ground to a **Persian land offensive** from 497 BCE. The fall of Miletus to the Persians that year and the death of Aristagoras undermined Ionian unity and, after a great naval defeat at the **Battle of Lade** in 494 BCE, the revolt fell apart.

In Italy, the **young Roman Republic** was rocked by **social dissent** in 494 BCE when the plebeians (the lower social groups) withdrew from Rome en masse in protest at their treatment by the patricians (the higher social groups); they threatened to set up an alternative state. They were persuaded back only by official recognition of their own representatives (tribunes).



The Battle of Lade

The Ionian Greek navy fought hard at Lade, but the prearranged defection of the Samians to the Persians led to its utter defeat.

This 19th-century painting shows the Spartan king Leonidas I (center, facing) and his men at the Battle of Thermopylae in 480 BCE. Thermopylae became a byword for heroic defiance against overwhelming odds.

THE KINGDOM OF MAGADHA

emerged as an important state in northern India under the rule of **Bimbisara** (r. 543–491 BCE), friend and protector of Gautama **Buddha** (c. 563–c. 486 BCE), who founded Buddhism (see 550–501 BCE). Bimbisara's son **Ajatashastru** (r. 491–461 BCE) strengthened the royal capital at Rajagirha and **built a center at Pataligrama** on the Ganges River, which later became **Pataliputra, the Mauryan royal capital**. By conquering Kosala and Kashi, and annexing the Vrijji confederacy, Ajatashastru turned Magadha into the **dominant power** on the Ganges Plain.

In China, the political system of the Spring and Autumn period evolved into the **Warring States period** (481–221 BCE), in which seven main states engaged in a constant round of diplomatic

maneuvers to weaken each other, periodically interrupted by outbreaks of war.

In 490 BCE, **Darius I** (548–486 BCE) of Persia decided to take revenge on the mainland Greeks for their support of the Ionian revolt. Darius despatched a **huge naval expedition** under Artaphernes and Datis, which sailed from Cilicia, landing first at Naxos

before seizing Eretria, which had aided the Ionians in 499 BCE. Although the **Athenians** appealed to Sparta for aid, the only help they received came from Plataea, which sent 1,000 reinforcements. The Athenians opted to march out to meet the **Persians** rather than wait for a siege, on the advice of their general, Miltiades (550–489 BCE). In 490 BCE at

Persian winged-lion rhyton

The Persian Empire enjoyed vast wealth, as illustrated by everyday items such as this golden drinking vessel. They directed huge resources toward the conquest of Greece.

7 THE NUMBER OF WARRING STATES

animals were often the inspiration for a rhyton's shape



c. 500 BCE Rice farming reaches Japan from China
c. 500 BCE In Central America the Zapotecs develop hieroglyphic writing
499 BCE Ionian revolt begins [to 494 BCE]
496 BCE First treaty between Carthage and Rome
492 BCE Persians invade and subdue Thrace and Macedonia
c. 500 BCE Darius I begins building Persepolis and the Persian Royal Road
c. 500 BCE Ironworking reaches Southeast Asia and Great Lakes region of Africa; in Africa, the Nok culture flourishes
c. 500 BCE The Mahabharata and the Puranas composed in India
494 BCE Withdrawal of the plebeians in Rome leads to creation of the tribunes of the plebs

490 BCE Darius I avenges Athens' involvement in the Ionian revolt; they destroy the city of Eretria, but Miltiades defeats them at the Battle of Marathon
486 BCE Carthaginian mariner Hanno is said to have sailed far down the west coast of Africa
486 BCE Egyptians revolt against Persian rule
485 BCE Darius I of Persia (b. 550) dies and is succeeded by his son Xerxes
483 BCE Athenians begin to build a fleet on the proceeds of the new silver mines at Mount Laurium
483 BCE Buddha (b. c. 563 BCE) dies
484 BCE Greek dramatist Aeschylus (525–456 BCE) wins his first Tragedy prize at Athens